

AC

AFRICAN CONNECTIONS

"Your Gateway to Africa"

Welcomes You to South Africa



Sawubona (Welcome in Zulu)

Thank you for choosing African Connections to provide comprehensive tour services for your upcoming “South Africa Return to the Motherland Tour” scheduled for March 8th – 17th 2026 (9 nights/10 days).

African Connections, “AC” is your Gateway to Africa. We have been a leader in African travel for over 20 years and the entire AC Team is preparing for your upcoming visit to South Africa.

We pride ourselves on delivery of outstanding concierge services and we are happy to assist you and provide you with information you’ll need to prepare for your journey.

When you reach South Africa, we will meet you at the airport when you arrive and assist you throughout your stay in South Africa.

Our team is knowledgeable and professional and proud to show you the wonders of South Africa, a country we know so well.

This welcome guide will provide you with information that will be helpful as you make your travel preparations.

Please review this information carefully. We welcome your questions and look forward to seeing you in South Africa soon!

Your Tour

You should book your tickets so that you depart from the USA on March 7th 2026, with your arrival in South Africa on March 8th 2026.

Your tickets should have you depart from South on March 17th 2026, and arrive back in the United States on August 18th 2026.

Your tour begins when you arrive in South Africa on March 8th and ends when we see you off at the airport on March 17th 2026.

South Africa Travel Requirements

South Africa is a tourist friendly destination, but it is important that you are aware of travel requirements and have your travel documents ready well in advance of your departure date. Please read the following information carefully.

Passports and Visas

A valid passport is required for all international travel.

U.S. citizens (U.S. passport holders) visiting the Republic of South Africa for ninety (90) days or less for tourism / business purposes do not need visas. However, there are other requirements to meet, including:

Passport: A valid U.S. passport with at least one blank visa page

Proof of travel: Proof of return or onward flights

Proof of funds: Proof of sufficient funds for the duration of your stay

Proof of purpose: Documents showing the purpose of your trip

Your passport must be valid for at least six months from the date of your arrival back in the United States. Check your passport expiration date to be sure it meets this requirement and if necessary, apply for a renewal as soon as possible. You will not be allowed to board your departure flight if your passport expiration date is within six months of your scheduled return to your home country.

Immunization and Medical Information

Yellow Fever Vaccination:

Yellow fever vaccination is not required of US citizens who have not been in an infested area.

If you get the Yellow Fever vaccine, be sure this is indicated in your yellow International Certificate of Vaccination or Prophylaxis (ICVP). **It is your responsibility to comply with all immunization requirements.**

Malaria Prevention and other Immunizations:

Your doctor might also recommend other vaccinations which are not mandatory for travel to South Africa. It is up to you to decide if you take any or all such recommended vaccinations as they are not required for entry into South Africa.

While it is not mandatory, we strongly recommend that you acquire anti-malarial medication. Malaria is a serious potential (but treatable) health threat, and you should take necessary precautions to minimize your risk.

It is also a good idea to bring your favorite mosquito repellant to further protect yourself from the mosquitos that you might encounter.

Prescription Medications:

If you take prescription medication, you are responsible for determining their legality in South Africa and note the following:

- We advise you to bring enough of your medication with you.
- Always keep your medication in the original container.
- Carry a copy of your prescription(s).
- Pack your medicine in your carry-on luggage not your checked luggage.

Travel Insurance

Travel Insurance is not included in your package. However, it is strongly recommended that you purchase travel insurance to cover any unexpected event that might interrupt or prevent your travel.

Our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click on the link below or go to our website www.africanconnections-usa.com to get a quote.

https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&ac_cam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTF TOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMNXVK3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4

Shopping in South Africa

You will love shopping in South Africa! Whether you are haggling for souvenirs at one of South A's traditional local markets, or shopping in one of its modern shops, South Africa has something for everyone! Known as the country of gold and diamonds, South Africa is the perfect destination to buy jewelry and precious stones.

Clothing and Packing

Bring comfortable outfits. Cotton or other fabrics that breathe will help you stay comfortable. It will be warm in South Africa. We advise that you bring a light sweater or jacket for evenings

and/or early mornings and wear comfortable shoes or sandals. There will be opportunities to swim, so pack your swimsuit and add a swim cover too.

Don't bring electrical appliances and gadgets. The electric outlets in South Africa are 230 volts, while U.S. appliances are 110 volts. **This means you will not be able to use your U.S. small appliances and devices in South Africa.** The exceptions are laptops, phone chargers and other such devices which are usually universal and should work in South Africa. You might need an adapter for these devices, however, as the outlets in South Africa are a different shape than those common in the U.S.

You can bring your own adapter or buy one when you arrive as adapters are very inexpensive in South Africa and are readily available.

Toiletries/Personal Items

Be sure you bring all your toiletries and personal items. While you will have opportunities to buy such things in South Africa, you might not be able to find the brands you prefer.

Customs Requirements

Passengers' obligations at South Africa Customs are outlined on the **South Africa Revenue Service** website, see www.sars.gov.za for details.

When you arrive in South Africa you will pass through South Africa Customs, and you might be asked if you have anything to declare. You must declare any commercial goods or currency more than \$10,000 that you bring into Senegal.

Money/Credit and Debit Cards/ATM's:

Cash

There is no limit on the amount of money you can bring into South Africa. However, as stated above, if you bring in more than \$10,000 in cash, you must declare it when you pass through customs on entry. If you bring in less than \$10,000, there is no need to declare any cash that you bring in.

You will have several opportunities to change your dollars for the local currency during your stay in South Africa. Please note that it is advisable that you bring any cash that you bring in either \$100 or \$50 bills as smaller denominations will be exchanged for a significantly lower exchange rate.

ATMs

There are ATMs in all the major cities you visit, but you will pay an international fee and a local bank fee for ATM transactions in addition to possibly receiving a lower exchange rate for each transaction.

Credit and Debit Cards

There will be a few places where you can use your credit or debit card, but for the most part, South Africa is a cash economy. If you intend to use your debit or credit card, when this option is available, you should inform your bank that you are traveling to South Africa to prevent a fraud alert or possible block of your card when you try to use it in South Africa.

Also, note, many of the businesses that take debit or credit cards use POS equipment which requires a pin number. While we all know our debit card pin number, most of us do not have or know a pin number for our credit cards. So, if you intend to use a credit card, contact your bank, and make sure you have and know the pin number associated with the card.

Note: the only credit cards accepted in South Africa are Visa and Mastercard.

Food and Water

Your tour package includes breakfast daily and other specified meals (lunch/dinner), including a Welcome Dinner with Cultural Performances.

You will be able to buy meals that are not included in the tour package at restaurants that we have carefully selected. There will be many food choices and you will be able to sample delicious South African dishes, but more familiar dishes will also be available to you. The average cost of a meal with a soft drink and water, in South Africa ranges from \$20-\$30.

Bottled water is readily available. However, the water in all of the hotels and restaurants that have been selected for you is potable and is safe for you to drink, use as ice cubes or to brush your teeth.

While some of your favorite snacks might be available in South Africa, and we will make regular stops for you to stock up on snacks, fruit, and drinks during the trip, it is advisable for you to bring the special snacks that you prefer.

Hotels and Restaurants in South Africa:

Hotels

You will be staying at hotels that have been carefully selected for you to ensure your comfort. These hotels are highly rated with clean comfortable rooms and well-trained staff. However, standards might vary from those to which you might be accustomed.

For example, while bath towels and hand towels are available and supplied at all the selected hotels, face cloths are not normally available. So, you should bring your own face cloths.

Rest assured; our ground staff will be available to address any issue that might arise.

Restaurants

We have carefully selected each of the restaurants you will visit on your tour. These restaurants will provide clean, wholesome food giving you the choice of local South African dishes or continental dishes that are more familiar.

While the food is tasty, South Africa restaurants are known for slow service, so you might have to exercise a bit of patience before your meal arrives. Whenever possible, our staff will help you to place your order in advance of arrival at a restaurant, to cut down on the wait time.

Cell Phone/Data Usage and Internet Service:

Before your departure to South Africa contact your mobile phone service provider and request international data service to access WhatsApp, or similar apps for internet-based communications. Such communications are significantly less costly than international roaming charges.

You could also ask for a one-month international voice package. While this could be costly, it is cheaper than the bill you will receive if you make calls without a call package.

If you make or receive international calls while you are in South Africa and you do not have the appropriate international call/data packages, you will be shocked when you receive your telephone service billing statement.

Other information that might be helpful as you prepare for your trip:

Country Profile

South Africa is an upper-middle-income country and the largest economy in Southern Africa. With cleaned beaches, natural attractions, and vibrant cosmopolitan cities. Southern Africa's rich culture is a vibrant tapestry woven from its diverse ethnic groups, historical experiences, and unique natural environment. Known as the "Rainbow Nation," South Africa celebrates a mix of traditions, languages, art forms, and cuisines that reflect its dynamic heritage. Visitors to South Africa can expect to be greeted by a sense of history and met with exceptional culture that has long been associated with its people.

Geography:

South Africa is well endowed with natural resources, including gold, oil, and bauxite. South Africa, officially the Republic of South Africa (RSA), is the southernmost country in Africa. Its nine provinces are bounded to the south by 2,798 kilometres (1,739 miles) of coastline that stretches along the South Atlantic and Indian Ocean; to the north by the neighbouring countries of Namibia, Botswana, and Zimbabwe; to the east and northeast by Mozambique and Eswatini; and it encloses Lesotho. Covering an area of 1,221,037 square kilometres (471,445 square miles), the country has over 62 million people. Pretoria is the administrative capital, while Cape Town, as the seat of Parliament, is the legislative capital. Bloemfontein has traditionally been regarded as the judicial capital. The largest and most populous city is Johannesburg, followed by Cape Town and the busiest port city in sub-Saharan Africa, Durban.

Economy:

South Africa is well endowed with natural resources, including gold, platinum, and coal. South Africa has a mixed economy. Its economy is Africa's largest, most technologically advanced and industrialised. It also has a relatively high gross domestic product (GDP) per capita compared to other countries in sub-Saharan Africa US\$16,080 at purchasing power parity as of 2023 ranked 95th.

South Africa is ranked 40th by total wealth, making it the second wealthiest country in Africa, in terms of private wealth South Africa has a private wealth of \$651 billion making South Africa's population the richest in Africa followed by Egypt with \$307 billion and Nigeria with \$228 billion.

The Currency

The South African Rand is the currency of South Africa. The currency code for Cedis is ZAR, and the symbol is R. The South African Rand to dollar exchange rate changes frequently. You will be able to exchange dollars for South African Rand when you arrive in South Africa at the prevailing rate at that time. There is no limit on the amount of cash you bring into South Africa, but you must declare any amounts over \$10,000. Lesser amounts do not need to be declared.

Language:

South Africa has 12 official languages: Zulu, Xhosa, Afrikaans, English, Pedi, Tswana, Southern Sotho, Tsonga, Swazi, Venda, and Southern Ndebele (in order of first language speakers), as well as South African Sign Language which was recognised as an official language in 2023. In this regard it is fourth only to Bolivia, India, and Zimbabwe in number. While all the languages are formally equal, some languages are spoken more than others. According to the 2022 census, the three most spoken first languages are Zulu (24.4%), Xhosa (16.6%), and Afrikaans (10.6%). Although English is recognised as the language of commerce and science, it is only the fifth most common home language, that of only 8.7% of South Africans in 2022; nevertheless, it has become the de facto lingua franca of the nation.

Government:

The Constitution of South Africa was adopted on 8 May 1996 and came into effect on 4 February 1997. It established a constitutional democracy with a government consisting of three branches: the Executive, Parliament and the Judiciary.

South Africa is a parliamentary republic, but unlike most such republics, the president is both head of state and head of government and depends for their tenure on the confidence of Parliament. The executive, legislature, and judiciary are all subject to the supremacy of the Constitution of South Africa, and the superior courts have the power to strike down executive actions and acts of Parliament if they are unconstitutional. The National Assembly, the lower house of Parliament, consists of 400 members and is elected every five years by a system of party-list proportional representation. The National Council of Provinces, the upper house, consists of ninety members, with each of the nine provincial legislatures electing ten members.

Current President: Matamela Cyril Ramaphosa

Deputy President: Paul Mashatile

History:

South Africa's history is a rich tapestry shaped by indigenous cultures, colonization, resistance, and reconciliation. South Africa was originally inhabited by the San and Khoikhoi peoples, known for their hunter-gatherer and pastoralist lifestyles. Later, Bantu-speaking peoples migrated southward, bringing agriculture, ironworking, and complex societies like the Zulu and Xhosa.

In 1652, the Dutch East India Company established a supply station at the Cape of Good Hope. This marked the beginning of European colonization. The Khoikhoi and San peoples faced displacement and conflict. Over time, Dutch settlers (later called Boers) expanded into the interior, developing a distinct Afrikaner identity. In 1806, the British seized control of the Cape Colony. Their abolition of slavery in 1834 caused tensions with the Afrikaners, prompting the Great Trek (1836–1840s), where Afrikaner pioneers moved inland, founding the Orange Free State and Transvaal Republic.

The discovery of diamonds (1867) in Kimberley and gold (1886) in the Witwatersrand transformed South Africa's economy and society. The British sought control of these resources, leading to conflicts with the Afrikaners, culminating in the Anglo-Boer War (1899–1902). Britain defeated the Boers and unified the colonies into the Union of South Africa in 1910, under British dominion.

In 1948, the National Party institutionalized apartheid, a system of racial segregation that oppressed the majority black population. Non-whites were stripped of political rights, forced into segregated areas, and subjected to harsh laws. Resistance movements like the African National Congress (ANC) and leaders like Nelson Mandela, Oliver Tambo, and Walter Sisulu mobilized protests, strikes, and international support. Mandela's imprisonment (1962–1990) became a global symbol of the fight against apartheid. Facing internal unrest and international pressure, apartheid began to crumble. In 1990, President F.W. de Klerk released Nelson Mandela and began negotiations to end apartheid. In 1994, South Africa held its first democratic elections, electing Nelson Mandela as the first black president.

Climate:

South Africa's climate is diverse due to its varying topography, ranging from Mediterranean in the southwest to subtropical in the northeast and semi-arid in much of the interior. The country generally enjoys abundant sunshine year-round. Temperatures vary with altitude, proximity to the ocean, and the season, with daily temperature variations more pronounced in the interior. The average temperature in summer is 30°C (86°F), while winter averages around 16°C (61°F).

The coolest period is during the winter months of May to August, with temperatures in high-altitude areas such as Johannesburg dropping to 5°C (41°F) at night, but warming up to 18°C (64°F) during the day. Coastal regions, like Cape Town, experience milder winters with minimums around 10°C (50°F) and highs of 18°C (64°F), often accompanied by rainfall. The eastern coastal areas around Durban have mild winters with temperatures ranging between 11°C (52°F) and 23°C (73°F).

South Africa's summer lasts from November to March, with warmer and wetter conditions. Johannesburg typically experiences temperatures ranging from 15°C (59°F) to 26°C (79°F), with afternoon thunderstorms common. Along the coasts, areas like Cape Town have dry, sunny weather with temperatures ranging between 16°C (61°F) and 27°C (81°F). Durban remains warm and humid, with temperatures averaging between 21°C (70°F) and 29°C (84°F).

The western regions, including the Karoo and the Kalahari, are arid and experience scorching summer highs, often exceeding 35°C (95°F). These areas cool significantly at night due to the desert-like climate.

March marks the end of summer and the beginning of autumn in South Africa. The weather is generally warm, sunny, and pleasant, making it a great time for tourists. In March the temperature Cape Town & Western Cape is 60–80°F (16–27°C) whilst that of Johannesburg is 60–85°F (16–29°C). March is an excellent time to visit South Africa! You get warm weather, fewer crowds, and great opportunities for outdoor activities, safaris, and coastal exploration.

Frequently Asked Questions

General Travel Information

1. Do I need a visa to visit South Africa?

U.S. citizens can visit South Africa for up to 90 days without a visa for tourism or business purposes. Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your travel date, with at least two blank pages.

2. What vaccinations do I need before traveling?

Routine vaccines (MMR, hepatitis A & B, tetanus) are recommended. If you plan to visit malaria-prone areas (such as Kruger National Park), malaria prophylaxis is advised.

3. Is South Africa safe for tourists?

South Africa is generally safe, but tourists should take precautions. Avoid walking alone at night, keep valuables secure, and use registered taxis or ride-hailing services like Uber.

4. What is the best time to visit South Africa?

South Africa is a year-round destination. March marks the end of summer and the beginning of autumn in South Africa. The weather is generally warm, sunny, and pleasant, making it a great time for tourists. In March the temperature Cape Town & Western Cape is 60–80°F (16–27°C) whilst that of Johannesburg is 60–85°F (16–29°C). March is an excellent time to visit South Africa! You get warm weather, fewer crowds, and great opportunities for outdoor activities, safaris, and coastal exploration.

5. What is the dress code in South Africa?

Casual, comfortable clothing is ideal. Light clothes for warm weather and a jacket for cool evenings are recommended. If going on safari, neutral colors and comfortable shoes are best.

6. Are public toilets available at tourist sites?

Yes, public toilets are available at most tourist attractions. Some may require a small fee, so carry loose change.

7. Is there internet access?

Hotels, restaurants, and cafes in major cities provide Wi-Fi. You can also get a local SIM card for better internet access.

8. **Is it allowed to take photographs of people?**

Always ask for permission before taking photos of individuals, especially in rural areas and cultural villages.

9. **What fitness level is required for sightseeing?**

A moderate level of fitness is required for most tours. Activities like hiking Table Mountain or going on safari drives may require some physical effort.

10. **What kind of shoes should I wear?**

Comfortable walking shoes are essential, especially for exploring nature reserves or city streets.

11. **How is the power supply in South Africa?**

Don't bring electrical appliances and gadgets. The electric outlets in South Africa are 230 volts, while U.S. appliances are 110 volts. **This means you will not be able to use your U.S. small appliances and devices in South Africa.** The exceptions are laptops, phone chargers and other such devices which are usually universal and should work in South Africa. You might need an adapter for these devices, however, as the outlets in South Africa are a different shape than those common in the U.S. You can bring your own adapter or buy one when you arrive

12. **Can I drink alcohol in South Africa?**

Yes, alcohol is available in restaurants, bars, and hotels. South Africa is famous for its wines and craft beers.

13. **Is smoking allowed in South Africa?**

Smoking is restricted in enclosed public spaces but allowed in designated areas.

14. **What food options are available in South Africa?**

South African cuisine includes dishes like braai (barbecue), bobotie, biltong, and bunny chow. Vegetarian and international options are also widely available. Your tour package includes breakfast daily and four (4) other meals (lunch/dinner), including a Welcome Dinner with Cultural Performances.

You will be able to buy meals that are not included in the tour package at restaurants that we have carefully selected. There will be many food choices and you will be able to sample delicious South African dishes, but more familiar dishes will also be available to you.

Money & Costs

15. What currency is used in South Africa?

The South African Rand (ZAR) is the official currency. Credit and debit cards are widely accepted, but cash is useful for small purchases.

16. How much does a meal cost in South Africa?

A meal at a mid-range restaurant costs about \$20-\$30, while street food or casual dining can be around \$3-\$6.

17. Can I use U.S. dollars in South Africa?

No, U.S. dollars are not accepted. You should exchange your money at banks or Fores Bureau.

Transportation & Getting Around

18. Do I need an international driver's license to rent a car?

Yes, an International Driving Permit (IDP) is required to rent a car. Driving is on the left side of the road.

19. Is public transportation safe?

Public transport options like minibus taxis are not recommended for tourists. Instead, use Uber, taxis, or guided tours.

Health & Safety

20. Is tap water safe to drink?

Tap water is safe to drink in major cities, but bottled water is recommended in rural areas. We will supply you with bottled water each day. It is also available in your hotel rooms. The hotels and the restaurants that we select for you, all use purified water to make their ice cubes. So you should feel free to add ice cubes to your drinks.

21. Do I need travel insurance?

Yes, travel insurance is highly recommended for medical emergencies, lost luggage, and trip cancellations.

However, our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click the link below or visit our website, www.africanconnections-usa.com, to get a quote.

https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&ac_cam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTFTOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMN XVK 3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4

22. Should I bring my own medicine?

Bring sufficient prescription medication for your trip. Pharmacies are available, but some medications may require a prescription.

Activities

23. Is there time for shopping?

Yes! South Africa is known for its craft markets, shopping malls, and souvenirs like beadwork, African art, and diamonds.

24. Can I make personal purchases?

Yes, budget around \$10-\$20 per day for snacks, drinks, and small souvenirs. Larger purchases can be made with credit cards.

Prepare to be Amazed!

Beneath the breathtaking beauty of South Africa lies a land of striking contrasts — where modern cities meet ancient landscapes, indigenous cultures thrive alongside global influences, and every sunrise promises a new adventure. South Africa is vibrant, diverse, and truly unforgettable. Get your cameras ready!

The African Connections Team is excited to welcome you to South Africa and stands ready to support you every step of the way as you prepare for this incredible journey through the Rainbow Nation!